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« Steven Gerrard made me see a different side of football »

GREG STEWART

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Mohun Bagan Super Giant was struggling to get going after three games in the Indian Super League (ISL) this season, with four points marking its worst start.

However, Greg Stewart turned the tide, assisting twice and scoring once as the Mariners defeated Mohammedan Sporting 3-0 in the first Kolkata derby of the ISL season.

He followed up this performance with a Player of the Match display against East Bengal, creating three chances, two of which resulted in goals.

Stewart, a two-time ISL Shield winner with two different teams, joined Mohun Bagan this summer and appears to have cemented his position as an inside forward in the squad.

He is fourth on the all-time list of most assists in the ISL, with 24 across three seasons.

There was a time, however, when the Scotsman considered giving up football.

"When you grow up playing on the streets of Scotland, then go into a team and reach a good level, and then the rejection at Hearts (happens)," Stewart told *Sportstar* in an exclusive interview. Hearts, or Heart of Midlothian Football Club, is a football club in Scotland.

"It hurt me a lot. I was actually at Rangers before Hearts and got released by Rangers at 14 and by Hearts at 16. At that point, I thought this game was not for me."

Stewart, who grew up idolising Rangers legends Paul Gascoigne and Ally McCoist, chose to step away from the game temporarily. He started working full-time at the Grangemouth Oil Refinery, practising twice a week and hoping that someday, he might get a shot at redemption.

"It was a great learning curve, something I don't want to go back to," Stewart laughed.

"I just went back and played with my mates, just a local team. Then I joined a really good amateur team before Cowdenbeath (a semi-professional side) signed me

up when I was 19. So, between 16 and 19, I could have just walked away. But because I love the game so much, I was never obviously going to give up," he added.

Way to the top

Stewart's stint at Cowdenbeath (40 goals, 19 assists) attracted interest from Scottish Premiership side Dundee United, which signed him ahead of the 2014-15 season.

"They (my family) were ecstatic. I gave up my day job to play full-time. So, all that hard work paid off, and the dream of playing football (professionally) became a reality," he said.

Stewart contributed to 59 goals (32 goals, 27 assists) for Dundee before moving to Birmingham City, where he trained alongside a budding Jude Bellingham.

"The ability he had — it was just about him getting on the pitch. He wouldn't care who he's playing against. He would play as if he's in a bout, or in a fight," Stewart recalled.

"He was 15, and I think Manchester City was trying to sign